



INNOVATION *fest*

UCL Grand Challenges

“homefolk” Problem Statement

How might homefolk use playful, gamified digital tools to communicate and build support for community-owned, low-carbon housing solutions?



Data-Empowered Societies



The Climate Crisis

About us

‘homefolk’ (uncapitalised) is a London-based social enterprise tackling the housing crisis. homefolk aim to introduce an affordable housing model, advocating for a scalable alternative to the broken private sector through ‘community-owned tiny-home villages’.



homefolk

The challenge

Instead of raising private capital for our R&D phase (like a commercial startup) we have worked alongside a variety of academic & NGO collaborators, understanding this is the best way to prevent co-optation of public space by an uncontrolled profit interest. Ahead, to make the pilot happen, we need to get significant capital backing over multiple years.

To gain support from the appropriate institutions & research funds, we need to frame the pilot as research proposal and engage our academic network. **To do this, we're asking students to create a gamified digital asset to communicate our housing model to potential research partners.**

Contextual information

The UK housing market

Our property market is increasingly monopolistic, prioritising profit over increasing access to affordable housing. The % of your income spent on housing costs affects your whole life - the UN definition of affordable housing is under 30% of your income on housing costs. Take a minute to calculate, the % that you, and other friends your age in London, are spending on housing? When this percent gets too high we see, overcrowding, poor maintenance, and in extreme cases leads to life threatening diseases like TB.

Because of our unique interdisciplinary team, we're applying a public health approach to the housing crisis - instead of responding to the end effects, homelessness, we iterate the recommendation of one of the UK's largest housing NGOs, Shelter: our communities need to find new models for housebuilding. **We need genuinely affordable homes that can't be privatised, or, sold by future governments.**



Contextual information (cont.)

Our housing model

Our model uses community-owned tiny-home villages as a scalable alternative to the UK's broken housing market. We want to transform marginal urban spaces, underused grey areas within cities, into affordable housing clusters.

Targeting "Generation Rent" (ages 20-35), the model empowers those priced out of urban areas to remain in their communities. 2023 costing suggests capital costs of approximately £50,000 per person for homes in our model—significantly below the £700,000 typical for new London homes.

Our funding model

homefolk is a volunteer run & led social enterprise working with a very low monetary input but high impact. Money we do raise through grant funding & our online e-store pays for marketing materials, design R&D, travel costs & volunteer expenses. The majority of development work to date has been done low/no cost.

Why digital tools?

Learning about the housing, climate, inequality & health crises can be massively stressful. Using publicly available data and coding tools, homefolk want to maximise the potential of digital tools for joy & fun. If we can gamify our resources and ideas, we can more effectively communicate, educate and build support for our pilot.

Our public spaces needs to better support existing communities' needs, empower people to have rich and fulfilling social lives and take hyperlocal action on the ongoing climate and biodiversity crises. Digital tools developed to help our project should try to embody the same values and ideas. **Tools that are intended to bring people together, in their creation and use, offer sustainable futures & contribute to open-source technology.**



Desired output

We want students in this hackathon to develop a resource (eg. A website or embedded web-based video game), that's easy-to-use, interactive and fun (gamified) that can help community stakeholders & academic partners to explore our organisation & the many aspects of our housing model evidence base, along different paths, from the perspective of new residents, planning teams and researchers.

It should be imaginative, creative, and get people to ask questions as they play through. We'd love to be able to add more 'paths' in the future. **With your help, we'll have a unique, artistic digital tool to engage academic & community partners when we formally start pitching our collaborative research proposal later this year.**

Secondary to the above, we recognise that there is already a huge community of amazing people following our project! For that reason, we'd like to give a 4 day 'social media takeover' to the team and encourage them to use gamified formats throughout to speak on Instagram and LinkedIn to help our circles understand the hackathon & how UCL are supporting students in the creation of digital tools that serve public needs in creative and fun ways 😊

Resources

These resources are designed to support your understanding of the organisation, sector context and the challenge they're facing. We recommend reviewing them ahead of Innovation Fest.

homefolk has prepared a separate technical brief & info pack, [accessible here](#).

